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H2 Economics: Essay and Case-Study Frameworks

The frameworks for case-study questions, diagrams, essays and evaluation, each with a worked example from our teaching notes.

LEVEL JC 1 and JC 2 · GCE A-Level H2 Economics (Syllabus 9570)



How to use this guide

Each section names one question type, gives its framework as numbered steps, works an example and lists the errors it prevents. Every framework is the **Hit** step of the SHARP routine we use in class:

S See	H Hit	A Apply	R Refine	P Practise
"Explain", "discuss" or "evaluate"? Which concept and which diagram?	Pick the framework for that question type.	Diagram, cause-and-effect chain, then evaluation.	Diagram labelled? Assumptions stated? A real verdict?	Timed case studies and essays, redone from memory.

The papers (SEAB 9570). Paper 1: two compulsory case studies of 30 marks each, 60 marks in total, 2 hours 30 minutes, 40% of the grade. Each case study has six or seven part-questions: about 12 marks of data response and about 18 marks of higher-order questions. Paper 2: answer three of six essay questions, at least one from Section A (mainly microeconomics) and one from Section B (mainly macroeconomics); each essay is 25 marks, split into part (a) for 10 marks and part (b) for 15; 75 marks, 2 hours 30 minutes, 60%.

1 Case-Study Data: Extract-Link-Apply

Paper 1 · data-response questions on tables, charts and extracts

Weak case-study answers either describe the data without theory or recite theory without the data. Extract-Link-Apply joins the two in three moves.

Steps

1. Skim the extracts for the country, period and economic context. Then read each question and mark the data it needs with the question number.
2. **Extract:** quote a specific figure, trend or statement, with its source (Table 1, Extract 2). Calculate the change rather than copying two numbers.
3. **Link:** connect the data to the economic concept it shows.
4. **Apply:** explain what the data shows in this specific context.
5. Match points to marks: 2 marks need 2 distinct points.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Illustrative data, not real figures: Table 1 shows an inflation rate that rose from 1.2% to 6.1% over two years; Extract 2 describes a post-pandemic recovery.

Extract "Table 1 shows that the inflation rate rose from 1.2% to 6.1% over the two years, an increase of 4.9 percentage points."

Link "This is consistent with demand-pull inflation driven by an increase in aggregate demand."

Apply "Extract 2 places the rise in the post-pandemic recovery, when pent-up demand outpaced the economy's productive capacity."

Errors this framework prevents

- Describing the data with no economic concept.
- Reciting theory with no reference to the data.
- “Rose sharply” with no figures, or a change in a rate given in per cent instead of percentage points.

2 Diagram Questions: Diagram-First

Paper 1 and Paper 2 · any question that says “use a diagram” or needs one

When a question asks you to use a diagram to explain, the diagram is the explanation, not decoration. Draw it before you write a sentence.

Steps

1. Identify the diagram: demand-supply, AD-AS, cost curves, exchange rate or production possibility curve.
2. Draw the initial equilibrium with fully labelled axes, curves and equilibrium point.
3. Show the change: shift the relevant curve, mark the new equilibrium, and label the change in price, quantity or output.
4. Annotate the areas that matter: deadweight loss, consumer surplus, an inflationary gap.
5. Only then write the explanation, and refer to the diagram directly.

Five rules for every diagram: give it a title (“Figure 1: Market for healthcare with positive externalities”); label both axes in full, such as General Price Level and Real GDP; use a ruler; show the change with arrows and before-and-after labels; refer to it in your text.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Cost-push inflation, written from the diagram.

“As shown in Figure 1, the rise in oil prices shifts AS from AS_1 to AS_2 . The general price level rises from GPL_1 to GPL_2 , while real GDP falls from Y_1 to Y_2 .” The cause of the shift, “rise in oil prices”, is also written on the diagram beside the arrow.

Errors this framework prevents

- A diagram the text never mentions.
- Curves or axes without labels, or no new equilibrium marked after a shift.
- A diagram drawn after the explanation, so the two do not match.

3 Information Failure: the Seven-Step Graph Explanation

Market failure (Theme 2) · turns a diagram into an explanation

The diagram earns the marks for showing the shift; these seven steps earn the marks for explaining it. Information failure takes three forms: missing information, inaccurate information (for example, persuasive advertising) and asymmetric information, which splits into adverse selection (before a deal) and moral hazard (after a deal). SEAB 9570 does not require diagrams for asymmetric information, adverse selection or moral hazard, so explain those in words.

Steps

1. **Cause:** why perceived value or available information differs from the true picture.
2. **Shift:** which curve moves, and in which direction.
3. **Real market:** a specific good, service or market.
4. **Quantify:** the over- or under-allocation, in units.
5. **Welfare:** whose surplus is lost, and why.
6. **Efficiency loss:** the deadweight loss, or a market that disappears entirely.
7. **Verdict:** name the exact failure: allocative inefficiency, or a missing market.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Missing information: childhood immunisations (from our Market Failure notes).

- 1 Parents who cannot or will not pay paediatrician fees miss information about a vaccine's benefits.
- 2 Demand without information lies to the left of demand with full information.
- 3 Childhood immunisations: a preventive service that families under-value without that information.
- 4 The market settles at Q_e instead of the socially optimal Q_s : an under-allocation of $Q_e Q_s$ units.
- 5 Families who would have benefited never buy the vaccine: a loss of potential consumer surplus.
- 6 The triangle between the two demand curves and the supply curve is the deadweight loss.
- 7 The market under-provides preventive care relative to the social optimum: allocative inefficiency, and market failure.

Errors this framework prevents

- Describing the diagram without stating the cause of the shift.
- Confusing adverse selection (hidden quality before a deal) with moral hazard (changed behaviour after it).
- No real market named, and no verdict naming the type of failure.

4 Theory Essay: DEED

Paper 2 · explaining and evaluating an economic mechanism

DEED gives every essay paragraph four parts. Put the diagram in as you explain, so it drives the argument instead of sitting beside it.

Steps

1. **Define** the key concept in one precise sentence: a working definition, not a textbook quotation.
2. **Explain** the cause-and-effect chain that shows how the concept operates.
3. **Evaluate**: test the assumptions, name the limitations or consider other outcomes.
4. **Diagram**: draw a precise, fully annotated diagram and refer to it in the explanation.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A negative externality in production.

Define "A negative externality is a cost imposed on third parties not involved in the production or consumption of the good."

Explain "When a factory emits pollution, nearby residents bear health costs not reflected in the market price, so the social cost of production exceeds the private cost."

Evaluate "This analysis assumes that the externality is measurable and that the government has enough information to set the optimal tax rate: conditions rarely met in practice."

Diagram MSC drawn above MPC; market output Q_m where $MPC = MPB$; socially optimal output Q_s where $MSC = MSB$; the deadweight loss shaded between Q_s and Q_m .

Errors this framework prevents

- A result stated with no mechanism, such as "people will spend less".
- "It depends on elasticity" as the whole evaluation.
- A diagram with unlabelled curves, or one the paragraph never refers to.

5 Policy Essay: DEED + Trade-Off

Paper 2 · evaluating fiscal, monetary, supply-side and trade policies

A list of advantages and disadvantages is not evaluation. After a DEED paragraph explains how the policy works, weigh it against three criteria and reach a justified weighting.

Steps

1. Explain how the policy works in a DEED paragraph.
2. **Effectiveness:** does it achieve its objective, and under what conditions?
3. **Feasibility:** can the government carry it out, given the budget, political considerations and time lags?
4. **Equity:** who gains and who loses, and are those effects acceptable?
5. Compare the alternatives on the same criteria, then state a specific weighting. For Singapore, use its context: a small open economy with no natural resources, an exchange rate managed by the MAS, and the CPF system.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A justified weighting, not “a combination of policies is best”.

“Expansionary fiscal policy is most effective in the short run given the severity of the recession, but must be complemented by supply-side measures to address the structural unemployment that monetary policy cannot reach.”

Errors this framework prevents

- Advantages and disadvantages listed with no weighing.
- “A combination of policies is best” with no priority or reason.
- Treating Singapore’s monetary policy as interest-rate policy: SEAB 9570 names the management of exchange rates for Singapore.

6 Higher-Order Evaluation: the Evaluation Chain

Paper 1 and Paper 2 · any question that asks you to discuss, assess or evaluate

Layer perspectives instead of writing “however, this may not always be the case”. Each layer moves the answer further up the mark scheme.

Steps

1. **Short run against long run:** does the impact change over time, and how?
2. **Stakeholders:** who benefits and who bears the cost (consumers, producers, government, workers, trading partners)?
3. **Assumptions:** what must be true for the argument to hold, and what happens if it is not (demand assumed price-elastic, but what if it is inelastic)?
4. **Policy conflicts:** does the policy trade off against another macroeconomic objective (lower unemployment against higher inflation)?

WORKED EXAMPLE

Question: “Will higher interest rates reduce inflation?” The same point, before and after.

Before: “Higher interest rates reduce inflation because people will spend less money.” A result with no mechanism, no diagram and no evaluation.

After: “Higher interest rates raise borrowing costs and reward saving, dampening consumption and investment. Lower aggregate demand eases demand-pull inflation (a leftward shift of AD). But the effect depends on how interest-sensitive spending is, works with a time lag, and is weaker against cost-push inflation, so it is necessary but not always sufficient.”

The time lag is layer one; interest-sensitivity and the type of inflation are layer three; the last clause is the verdict.

Errors this framework prevents

- “However, this may not always be the case” with no condition named.
- Ignoring who bears the cost of the policy.
- Missing the conflict with another macroeconomic objective.

7 Case-Study Evaluation: Context-Driven Judgement

Paper 1 · the final, higher-order parts of each case study

The last parts of each case study demand evaluation, and the evaluation must belong to the economy in the case, not to textbook theory in general.

Steps

1. Name the economy’s own constraints from the extracts, such as limited fiscal space or dependence on commodity exports.
2. Use the data in the extract to support or challenge the policy recommendation.
3. Choose an evaluation pattern: **conditions** (does a named condition hold here?), **magnitude** (is the effect large enough to matter?), **time horizon** (short run against long run) or **trade-off** (who gains, who loses?).
4. Give a verdict that states its conditions.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Two verdicts from our notes (illustrative data).

Conditions: “Devaluation would improve the trade balance only if the Marshall-Lerner condition is met, and the data in Table 2 suggests the country’s export demand elasticity is low, limiting the policy’s effectiveness in the short run.”

Magnitude: “While the subsidy reduces the cost of solar panels, the reduction from \$15,000 to \$13,500 represents only a 10% decrease: unlikely to be the decisive factor for households already deterred by payback periods of 8 to 10 years.”

Errors this framework prevents

- An evaluation that would fit any country.
- A verdict with no conditions attached.
- Ignoring the data the case study provides.

Summary: every framework on one page

Question type	Framework	Steps
Case-study data	Extract-Link-Apply	Skim, then map data to questions; Extract a figure with its source; Link it to a concept; Apply it to the context; one point per mark.
Diagram questions	Diagram-First	Identify the diagram; draw and label the initial equilibrium; show the shift and the new equilibrium; annotate areas; then explain, referring to it.
Information failure	Seven-step graph explanation	Cause, Shift, Real market, Quantify, Welfare, Efficiency loss, Verdict.
Theory essay	DEED	Define; Explain the cause-and-effect chain; Evaluate the assumptions; Diagram that drives the argument.
Policy essay	DEED + Trade-Off	DEED paragraph; weigh Effectiveness, Feasibility, Equity; compare alternatives; a specific, justified weighting in context.
Higher-order evaluation	Evaluation Chain	Short run against long run; stakeholders; assumptions; policy conflicts.
Case-study evaluation	Context-Driven Judgement	The economy’s own constraints; the extract’s data; a pattern (conditions, magnitude, time horizon, trade-off); a verdict with conditions.

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